

EG US Daily: Anyone but Platner leaves Democrats better off

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US Daily

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Anyone but Platner leaves Democrats better off

- * Anyone but Platner leaves Democrats better off
 - * USA Rare Earth inquiry a preview of Democrats' post-midterms agenda
 - * US strikes likely after Iranian attacks on shipping
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Anyone but Platner leaves Democrats better off. It looks this morning like a “when,” not an “if,” on Graham Platner ending dropping out of Maine Senate race, where he is challenging Senator Susan Collins (R-ME).

* Per Maine statute, Platner has until 13 July to exit the race; the state Democratic committee then has until 27 July to name a replacement, who will not go through the primary process. With Platner's congressional supporters rapidly dropping their support, and Democrats' national campaign apparatus having said it will not run ads in the state with him as the candidate, it is hard to see how Platner can stay in.

* Finding a replacement might not be straightforward. A bevy of high-profile Maine Democrats already declined the chance to run against Collins this year, leading to a crowded Democratic gubernatorial primary. One of the losers in that primary would likely become the candidate; former Maine Senate president Troy Jackson and former deputy CDC director Nirav Shah have both been floated as options.

* The silver lining is that Democrats will likely run a more reliable candidate, meaning the drama of recent weeks could end up as a wash. Recent polling has indicated that Platner's personal issues were dragging him down relative to the state's partisan baseline; Shah or Jackson—or another figure—would likely run closer to that baseline. Betting markets appear to have bought into this logic, with Democrats' odds of winning the seat having increased since yesterday. On net, that means the race still leans narrowly Democratic, with the selection of the next Democratic candidate the next key signpost.

USA Rare Earth inquiry a preview of Democrats' post-midterms agenda. Congressional Democrats have asked Cantor Fitzgerald, the bank formerly run by Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick and now run by his sons, for information on the bank's role in the US government's recent \$1.6 billion investment in

USA Rare Earth.

* Coming on the back of a Democratic request for information on United Arab Emirates officials' investments in World Liberty Financial, this is the latest instance of congressional Democrats seeking information on business dealings involving President Trump or Cabinet members.

* With these requests, Democrats are accomplishing two goals: turning Trump and other Cabinet officials' business dealings into midterm campaign issues; and laying the groundwork for oversight investigations run by a likely Democratic-controlled House (and potentially Senate) after the midterms.

* Since Democrats' legislative agenda has no prospect of moving forward under a Republican president, oversight investigations will become perhaps the primary focus for the party in 2027 if they win the House; while these investigations likely will not affect the White House's approach, they will be a headache for potential 2028 contenders and for the leadership of companies that have done business with the White House, which will face the prospect of being hauled in front of Congress for testimony.

US strikes likely after Iranian attacks on shipping. Iran attacked several ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz in the past 24 hours. We expect limited strikes in retaliation, but below the threshold that would lead to serious escalation and would break the ceasefire.

* Limited strikes from both sides are in line with our basecase of a shaky ceasefire. Neither the US nor Iran wish to return to full hostilities, but the lack of clarity over Iran's control over the Strait of Hormuz in the Memorandum of Understanding gives it room to demand that all ships use its preferred route and pay some sort of toll.

* Enforcement of this—through strikes on ships using an alternate route—will inevitably cause retaliatory US strikes, as the US understands the MOU as guaranteeing full freedom of navigation of the strait.

* Going forward the US will continue assisting the movement of ships through the strait and likely respond to any further Iranian attacks. Iran, for its part, is seeking an arrangement with regional actors to institutionalize its status regarding the strait and actively holding discussions with them.

Quote of the Day

"Politics, at least in the Democratic primary, has evolved to the point where folks who don't know this issue very well are looking for guidance." - Rep. Greg Landsman (D-OH) speaking about the lack of a Democratic party line on Israel; the issue has already split the Democratic electorate, and lawmakers are becoming increasingly concerned that without voting guidance from Democratic leadership Republicans will use it to divide their caucus.

On the Radar

7-8 July: NATO summit in Turkey

13 July: Congress returns from July 4 recess

13 July: Deadline for Graham Platner to withdraw from Maine Senate race if Democratic Party wishes to name replacement

14 July: Fed chair Kevin Warsh testifies before the House Financial Services Committee.

15 July: Senate Judiciary Committee confirmation hearing for Attorney General nominee Todd Blanche

24 July: Section 122 tariffs expire

27 July: Deadline for Maine Democratic Party to name Senate candidate if Platner drops out

4 August: Michigan primary election

3 November: National midterm elections

EG United States

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Kendal Walker

Senior Analyst, United States

walker@eurasiagroup.net

Jason Walter

Researcher, United States

walter@eurasiagroup.net

Gregory Brew

Senior Analyst, Iran & Energy

+1 646 259 3207

brew@eurasiagroup.net

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Positive: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a positive impact on the macro business environment

Neutral: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a neutral or negligible impact on the macro business environment

Negative: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a negative impact on the macro business environment

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